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According to Shariff, the company's robust partnerships with leading open source technology platforms play a key role in bringing new business. The company has documented cases where CIOs approached it after consulting analyst reports such as 'Gartner Magic Quadrant for Horizontal Portals, 2013', in which Liferay is rated as a 'Leader'; or 'Forrester Wave for Enterprise Content Management, 2013', in which Alfresco is reported as a 'strong performer'. "We are able to get repeat business from our clients as our solutions and services overcome specific business challenges. For example, CIGNEX Datamatics helped a leading Mexico-based hotel group, Grupo Posadas, achieve its business and technology goals with an innovative, integrated hospitality portal solution (Liferay + Alfresco) reducing the TCO by 40 per cent. In another key example, we developed a Big Data solution to improve productivity for a leading European manufacturing company by enabling a 10 times better search performance, at a cost that was 20 times lower compared to proprietary solutions."

The company had helped a mobile carrier to manage the life cycle of serving videos on mobile devices at a rapid speed (5 million/hour) with huge data volumes. This was not possible earlier due to high costs and low scalability. Now it is possible with big data

Community involvement

Shariff firmly believes that any business built around the open source framework has to eventually fall back on the global open source community for support. "As an organisation, we are highly sensitive to the needs of the open source community and go out of our way to give back to it. For instance, CIGNEX Datamatics has been actively contributing to the Liferay community with

over 4000 posts in various forums, blogs and wikis, and members of our team have been invited to numerous Liferay events as keynote speakers. Like I mentioned earlier, our team members have authored seven books on Liferay expertise, and regularly conduct training sessions and workshops in various countries, including India, as we are a certified training partner for Liferay. We have been awarded the 'Liferay Community Excellence Award' in 2011, 2012 and 2013 as a result of our contribution to the Liferay community," says Shariff.

The company has also developed frameworks such as the Open Contract Manager—a contract lifecycle management system that is available for free download.

The vision

The company's immediate plan is to maximise its market presence in the portals and Big Data solutions business. "We want to continue with our innovation through new solutions built on open source frameworks, including mobile portals built on Liferay, RAPIDO (a content management publishing framework), Open Contract Manager, a mobile media site using Drupal and MongoDB, etc. Our vision is to be amongst the largest open source companies and to become a US\$ 100 million company by 2015, with the stated aim to improve enterprise productivity through the adoption of open source solutions," quips Shariff.

According to Shariff, open source solutions have come of age in the enterprise space and have been experiencing robust growth in the past few years. Gartner predicts that by 2016, almost 99 per cent of the Global 2000 firms will be using some form of open source software.

And what is Shariff's advice to nascent entrepreneurs who are hesitant to adopt the open source business model? "We advise budding entrepreneurs to believe in the open source movement, as this is the only future worth talking about. CIGNEX Datamatics embodies this hallowed principle not only in our corporate vision, 'Making Open Source Work' for enterprises but also, intrinsically, within our own organisation. A lot of our internal applications such as the Intranet, Extranet, document repositories, helpdesk ticketing generation for admin, HR, IT and support teams are based on open source," says Shariff, as he signs off.

CIGNEX Datamatics intends to stay at the top by widening its customer base and selling more open source solutions. So will other companies follow suit? 

By Priyanka Sarkar

The author is a member of the editorial team. She loves to weave in and out the little nuances of life and scribble her thoughts and experiences in her personal blog.